

art, a painting could depict an extremely luxurious lifestyle, with a little skull painted in one corner.

'In many senses, the Baroque period was characterized by *vanity* or affectation. But at the same time a lot of people were concerned with the other side of the coin; they were concerned with the *ephemeral* nature of things. That is, the fact that all the beauty that surrounds us must one day perish.'

'It's true. It is sad to realize that nothing lasts.'

'You think exactly as many people did in the seventeenth century. The Baroque period was also an age of conflict in a political sense. Europe was ravaged by wars. The worst was the Thirty Years' War which raged over most of the continent from 1618 to 1648. In reality it was a series of wars which took a particular toll on Germany. Not least as a result of the Thirty Years' War, France gradually became the dominant power in Europe.'

'What were the wars about?'

'To a great extent they were wars between Protestants and Catholics. But they were also about political power.'

'More or less like in Lebanon.'

'Apart from wars, the seventeenth century was a time of great class differences. I'm sure you have heard of the French aristocracy and the Court of Versailles. I don't know whether you have heard much about the poverty of the French people. But any display of magnificence presupposes a display of power. It has often been said that the political situation in the Baroque period was not unlike its art and architecture. Baroque buildings were typified by a lot of ornate nooks and crannies. In a somewhat similar fashion the political situation was typified by intrigue, plotting, and assassinations.'

'Wasn't a Swedish king shot in a theater?'

'You're thinking of Gustav III, a good example of the sort of thing I mean. The assassination of Gustav III wasn't until 1792, but the circumstances were quite baroque. He was murdered while attending a huge masked ball.'

'I thought he was at the theater.'

'The great masked ball was held at the Opera. We could say that the Baroque period in Sweden came to an end with the murder of Gustav III. During his time there had been a rule of "enlightened despotism," similar to that in the reign of Louis XIV almost a hundred years earlier. Gustav III was also an extremely vain person who adored all French ceremony and courtesies. He also loved the theater ...'